

Do negative expressives impose contextual constraints in a second language?

Michelle Stankovic¹, Morgan Moyer¹ & Isidora Stojanovic^{1,2}

¹Department of Language & Translation Sciences, Pompeu Fabra University, Barcelona, Spain
²Institut Jean Nicod, (CNRS, ENS-PSL, EHESS), Paris, France

PRE-REGISTRATION POSTER 5



Negative expressives are less acceptable without supporting context, and target-oriented support (*Marco is a bad person*) appears to be preferred over agent-oriented support (*they hate Marco*). We test whether this context sensitivity is specific to expressives (vs. adjectives), driven by valence, or both. We investigate whether it is reduced in L2, where affective responses may be weaker, or preserved across languages as a more stable pragmatic constraint. Across **two experiments** with **Italian–English and English–Italian bilinguals**, we found **negative expressives show a strong contextual constraint in both L1 and L2**. We found **no reliable evidence that L2 attenuated these context effects**. The contextual-support effect was also **larger for the negative expressive than for ordinary negative adjectives**.

BACKGROUND

Expressives (e.g., asshole) do more than describe someone: they **convey a negative evaluation**. Traditional accounts (e.g., Potts, 2005; Schlenker, 2007) treat this meaning as mainly **reflecting the speaker’s attitude** → Therefore, the context should *not* need to show that the target *is* bad.

However:

the jerk papers → When is it ok to call someone a **jerk**? An experimental investigation of expressives
Literally ‘a jerk’: an experimental investigation of expressives in predicative position
Bianca Cepollaro¹ · Filippo Domaneschi² · Isidora Stojanovic³
Filippo Domaneschi¹, Bianca Cepollaro² and Isidora Stojanovic¹

Does context matter?

Cepollaro et al. (2021) found that **negative expressives seem to require contextual support** and aren’t driven solely by negative valence
Supporting context > Neutral context

Are some contexts preferred over others?

Domaneschi et al. (2025) found preference for **Target-oriented > Agent-oriented** for a negative expressive (‘jerk’) and negative adjectives (‘rude’)
Knowing that the target is bad is preferred to knowing that the speaker dislikes the target: **we prefer when bad evaluations happen to bad people**
This pattern reversed for positive predicates: Agent-oriented > Target-oriented
→ This raises the possibility that **valence itself changes how much contextual support an evaluation needs**

But what is actually driving the contextual constraint?

Is “**asshole**” special because: it is an **expressive**? because it is **negative**? or because **negative + expressive are a special combination**?

Bilinguals/L2 speakers provide a diagnostic test: Can reduced L2 emotionality help separate affect from pragmatic effects? Emotional language is often experienced **less intensely in a second language** (Dewaele, 2004; Ferré et al., 2018; Toivo & Scheepers, 2019). Therefore:
→ If contextual sensitivity is partly driven by **affective force**, it should be **reduced in L2**.
→ If it reflects a stable **semantic/pragmatic constraint**, it should be **preserved across L1 and L2**.

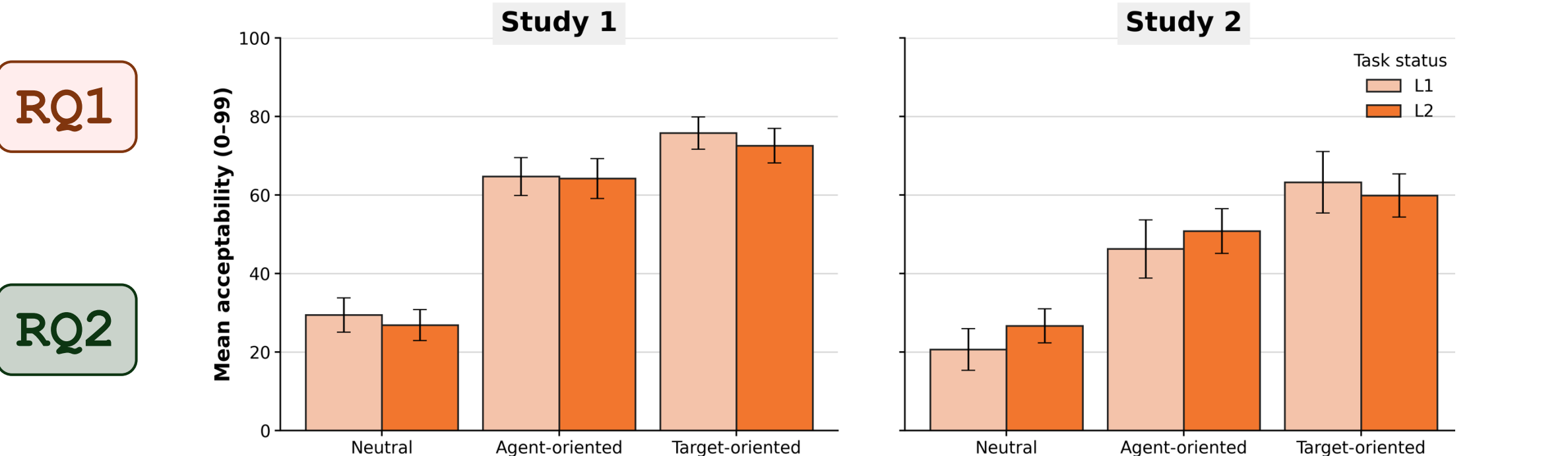
THE PRESENT STUDY: 2 EXPERIMENTS

Work assessing the impacts of valence should be **replicated in a bilingual context** in order to highlight whether this is a **universal process**, or whether it is moderated by language use. By testing **context, valence, lexical type**, and **language nativeness** within a single paradigm, we differentiate whether acceptability depends on interaction between attitude attribution, contextual support, and affective impact.
Key extensions:
Bilingual sample: switching L1-L2 order allows for further generalisation
Updated translations: changed the Eng translation from ‘jerk’ to ‘asshole’
Balanced design: including positive expressive term (analysis in progress) to balance the valence condition

PRELIMINARY ANALYSIS & RESULTS

Acceptability ~ ContextCondition × Nativeness
+ (1 + ContextCondition || Participant)
+ (1 | Vignette)

RQ1: Knowing something negative about the target licensed the expressive more strongly than knowing only that the speaker dislikes the target:
Neutral < Target-oriented > Agent-oriented



RQ2: No reliable evidence of L2 attenuation However, a non-significant L1–L2 interaction does not demonstrate equivalence. *L2 contextual sensitivity varied with bilingual experience, particularly immersion, language use and learning context.*

Declarations:

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RQ1: CONTEXT
Do bilinguals replicate the contextual constraint asymmetry for negative expressives?

RQ2: LANGUAGE
Does L2 (vs. L1) attenuate or reorganise the contextual-licensing effect?

RQ3: LEXICAL CATEGORY
Are effects uniform across categories, or do expressives (vs. ordinary negative descriptors) differ?

design:

DESIGN: 3 × 2 × 2 (within) × 2 (between)
within-subjects
Context (3): Neutral, Agent-oriented, Target-oriented
Lexical type (2): Expressive, evaluative adjective
Valence (2): Negative, Positive
-counterbalanced, Latin-square design
between-subjects
Nativeness (2): First (L1), Second (L2), randomised
Moderator analyses: proficiency, AoA, exposure/use, language choice, immersion, learning context and accent are analysed continuously in separate models, including interactions with Context, Lexical Type and Valence.

materials:

expressive	negative		positive	
	asshole	stronzo	sweetheart	tesoro
adjective	liar	bugiarda.	kind.	gentile
	obscene	osceno.	graceful	elegante
	rude	scortese	wise	saggia
	unreliable	inaffidabile	careful	scrupolosa
	lazy	pigra	reliable	affidabile
	mean	meschina	loyal	leale
	indiscreet	indiscreta	patient	paziente
	cruel	crudele	cautious	cauta
	disloyal	sleale	discreet	riservata

participants:

Experiment 1 (n = 295)	
	*missing data
Experiment 2 (n = 187)	
L2 Reading proficiency	6.69 (2.82)
L2 Age of Acquisition	12.57 (9.86)
L2 use percentage	13.59 (10.64)
L2 family immersion	9.66 (15.83)
L2 country immersion	3.71 (7.87)
L2 school/work immersion	3.13 (4.95)
L2 family learning context	4.63 (4.11)
L2 friends learning context	4.82 (3.75)
L1 Reading proficiency	9.68 (1.22)
L1 Age of Acquisition	1.50 (2.11)
L1 use percentage	76.04 (14.92)
L1 family immersion	31.52 (12.92)
L1 country immersion	31.16 (13.45)
L1 school/work immersion	26.22 (13.26)
L1 family learning context	8.75 (2.13)
L1 friends learning context	8.22 (SD 2.89)

1

Experimental manipulation

The background and target utterance remained the same.
Only the context changes

Sara, Luca and Chiara are sitting at the bar with some friends.
At another table Marco is drinking a coffee.

Context: **Neutral** (No additional information) | **Agent-oriented** (Luca hates Marco.) | **Target-oriented** (Marco is a bad person.)

How acceptable do you consider the statement ?

completely unacceptable ————— completely acceptable

2

1. LEAP-Q (Marian et al., 2007): language history, proficiency, age of acquisition, current language exposure/use, reading/speaking language choice, immersion in country/family/school-work, learning context

2. Word ratings: Participants rated **26 target words** for valence (1–9) and arousal (1–9)

3. Comprehension check

rude

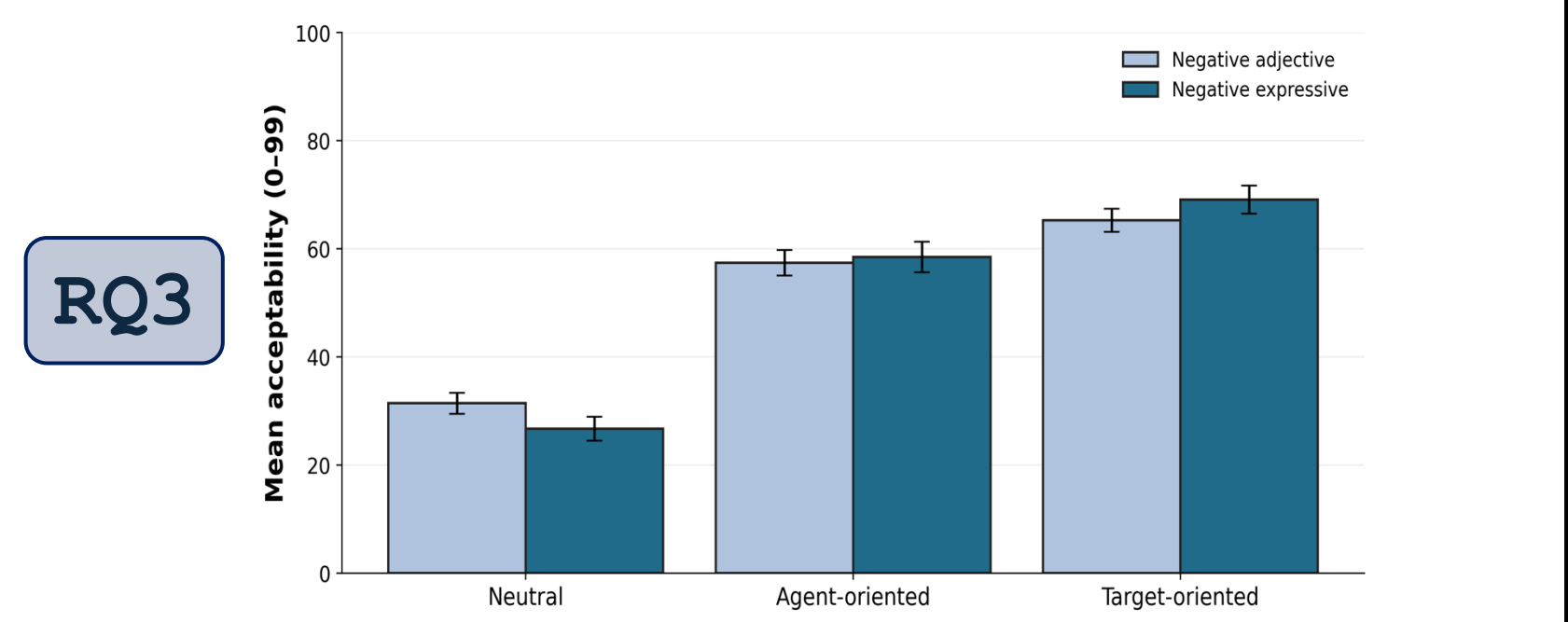
unhappy 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 happy
calm 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 excited

☐ I don't understand this word. **Next**

Note: [1] Full exclusion criteria has not yet been applied. Therefore, future analyses may be different to those presented in this poster. [2] Some participants were erroneously recruited through a Prolific error (e.g., not Italian speakers or not proficient bilinguals). Data analysis is ongoing. [3] A technical error prevented numerical LEAP-Q score from being recorded in Experiment 1. [4] If not specified, measured on 10-pt scale

Acceptability ~ ContextCondition × LexicalType × Group
+ (1 + ContextCondition || Participant)
+ (1 | Vignette)

RQ3: Contextual support mattered **more for negative expressives** than for negative adjectives. The Supporting-vs-Neutral effect larger for expressives (ps ≤ .003). But, **TO vs. AO did not reliably differ by Lexical Type**.



Limitation: One repeated negative expressive per language limits lexical generalisation.

PRELIMINARY CONCLUSIONS:

*Contextual licensing of negative expressives appears to reflect more than a simple speaker-attitude effect.
*The pattern is compatible with a **stable pragmatic constraint that remains available in L2**.
***Bilingual experience may still shape how strongly contextual information is used**, motivating individual-differences analyses.
*Acceptability alone cannot determine whether the constraint is fundamentally semantic or pragmatic.
ONGOING ANALYSES:
-Finalise participant exclusions and rerun preregistered analyses.
-Analyse valence and arousal ratings. Model the impact of emotional intensity on acceptability ratings
-Test whether effects differ by valence and lexical type.
-Model bilingual variability: proficiency, AoA, language use and immersion continuously to test individual differences in L2 effects. Final analyses to be rerun after exclusions and extended to word ratings.
FUTURE EXPERIMENTS IN PLANNING:
-Manipulate the **syntactic position** of the pejorative (e.g., that asshole Luigi vs Luigi is an asshole)
-Extend the paradigm to **other types of expressives**, including mixed expressives, hybrid evaluatives and value-associated terms.

Thank you for your time!



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